

SHRIYANS BHANDARI, 30
RAMESH DHAMI, 30
Mumbai

FACT SHEET

Name of company
GreenSole Foundation

What they do
Refurbish discarded shoes, and turn waste into school bags and mats

Founded in: 2016

Annual turnover
Around Rs 7 crore

> **"WE WON THE 2015 EDITION OF 'EUREKA!,' ORGANISED BY IIT BOMBAY. OVER 7,000 HAD PARTICIPATED IN THE COMPETITION BUT OUR SOCIAL STARTUP MADE THE CUT. THIS MOTIVATED US"**
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> **SHRIYANS BHANDARI**

Marathoners Shriyans Bhandari and Ramesh Dhami faced a peculiar problem. They used several pairs of shoes every year, leaving them with a pile of old ones. "We wanted to recycle old shoes, but the concept of these being recycled and refurbished was unheard of," says Bhandari.

Originally from Udaipur, Bhandari was in Mumbai for his education. There, he bonded with Dhami, who had run away from his village in Uttarakhand at the age of nine to become an actor. What brought them together was their shared passion for running.

In 2016, the duo started the GreenSole Foundation to recycle shoes into chappals and new footwear, largely funded through CSR donations. Now, they also make school bags and mats from discarded flex boards, banners and old clothes. The footwear is donated to children from underprivileged backgrounds, such as students at the Zilla Parishad Primary School in Pirangut near Pune, who might otherwise walk several kilometres barefoot or in ill-fitting shoes. The bags replace their hand-me-downs and worn satchels used to carry schoolbooks. "This even motivates children to go to school," says Bhandari.

Dhami, who lived on the streets for years before being taken in by a voluntary group, recalls how he and other street children would walk barefoot along railway tracks to collect plastic bottles and scrap, often getting their feet pierced by sharp objects and shards of broken beer bottles.

An estimated 350 million pairs of shoes are discarded every year across the world, while around 1.5 billion people suffer from diseases that could be prevented by wearing proper footwear. "Worldwide, only 3 per cent of shoes are upcycled, while the rest make their way to landfills," notes Dhami, adding that the challenge was to ensure this footwear was recycled and reached those who couldn't afford a decent pair.

GreenSole has over 15 collection centres across India where used shoes can be donated. According to Bhandari, companies like Amazon and Adidas also hand over rejected or returned shoes to them. So far, the foundation has distributed more than 700,000 pairs of shoes, upcycled at its units in Vasai and Bhiwandi near Mumbai. "Otherwise, these shoes would have ended up in landfills," says Bhandari. The duo now aims to scale up operations, distributing over one million refurbished shoes by 2026, and to open skilling centres in Maharashtra and Karnataka to train and empower local communities. They also have plans to venture into the for-profit retail business. In their care, more shoes can walk into new lives. ■